

LIGHTBULB MOMENT

Shine a light into a comic strip, swap what the characters are thinking, and watch the punchline twist.

COMIC

TWIST

LIGHT



WHAT IS IT?

A puzzle game that takes place inside a newspaper comic strip. You play the little lightbulb that pops up over a character's head when they get an idea. Every page starts by playing its original joke, which is completely predictable. Then the editor crosses out the punchline and asks for a better one.

You can't move anybody. You get one or two spotlights and the power to swap what two characters are thinking. Whoever is lit gets to act, and they only notice things that are lit. Press ACTION and see if the chaos goes the way you planned.

HOW A PAGE PLAYS

1

WATCH THE ORIGINAL

The strip plays its usual ending.

2

RED PEN

One word of the punchline gets crossed out.

3

MOVE THE LIGHT

See what people in the dark are thinking.

4

SWAP THOUGHTS

Drag a bubble onto another lit character.

5

ACTION!

Everyone in the light goes DING.

6

CHAIN REACTION

Things collide, lamps flick on, more people join in.

7

NEW ENDING

Match the new punchline, or rewind and try again.

COMIC

- The pieces you play with are **thought bubbles**. Dragging one from head to head is the main move.
- A lightbulb over a head means someone had an idea. Here, that's literally what makes a character act.
- The panel border is the edge of the world. A scared character can run straight out of the comic.
- Every run is turned into a short captioned strip, so even your failures read like comics.

LIGHT

- Only lit characters do anything.** Most pages give you one or two spotlights, each three slots wide.
- Nobody can see things in the dark. Leave the cookie unlit and the kid walks over to the broccoli instead.
- You can only swap thoughts between two characters who are both lit.
- Stepping on a floor switch turns on a lamp halfway through a scene and wakes up whoever is under it.

TWIST

- You never start from scratch. Each page already has a working joke, and you watch it first.
- Your goal is that same punchline with one word swapped in red pen: *the ~~Boss~~ Dog ate the cake.*
- The original strip doubles as a clue. It shows you what people in the dark were thinking.
- Sometimes the light shows something odd, like sweet old Grandma being terrified.

WHAT PLAYING FEELS LIKE

- Thoughts can only be swapped, never created or deleted. Fixing one character always hands the problem to someone else.
- Footprints show where each lit character will step first. Working out what happens after that is your job.
- A run takes a few seconds, rewind keeps your setup, and nothing punishes you for trying something silly.
- The good moments are the chains: a scare sends someone onto a switch, a lamp comes on, and the dog wins the race by one step.
- Lots of CHOMP!, BONK! and ZOOM!, plus a TWIST! stamp when you get it right.

EXAMPLE

PAGE 6 · THE BOSS'S BIRTHDAY

ORIGINAL

The spotlight is on the Boss. He walks to the cake: **CHOMP!**
"The Boss ate the birthday cake."

YOUR EDIT

The light shows Grandma is **SCARED**. Swap that with the Boss's **HUNGRY** and move the light onto both of them.

TWIST

Boss panics → runs onto the pedal **CLICK!** →
 lamp on **DING!** → Dog spots the cake →
CHOMP!
*"The ~~Boss~~ **DOG** ate the Boss's cake. The Boss ran out of the comic."* **TWIST!**

HOW IT WORKS

- Each page is one comic panel with a single row of 7 to 12 spots. Characters walk left and right. The border is the edge of the world.
- The cast (Boss, Dog, Cat, Grandma, Kid, Intern and others) all follow the same rules. What makes them different is how they look and react.

- Each character is thinking exactly one of four things:

HUNGRY

Goes to the nearest food they can see and eats it.

SLEEPY

Goes to the nearest free seat and nods off.

ANGRY

Goes after the nearest person standing up. BONK!

SCARED

Runs from anyone who gets close, even out of the comic.

- Some light comes from your spotlights, some is fixed (a fireplace, an open fridge), and some comes from lamps wired to floor switches.
- While you plan, every change to the light or the thoughts immediately updates where each character wants to go.
- Pressing ACTION runs the whole scene step by step, with no randomness. The same setup always gives the same result, so every outcome can be worked out.
- A goal is a small set of facts (who ate what, who fell asleep, who got bonked, who ran away). Failed runs still get their own funny last panel.

WHY WE THINK IT WORKS

- The themes aren't decoration. Take away the light and there's nothing to decide. The twist is the goal of every page.
- You only ever do three things: place a light, swap two thoughts, press ACTION. The depth comes from how the characters bump into each other.
- Losing is still fun to watch, which keeps people trying.
- Because the rule set is small, we can spend our jam hours on feel and polish instead of piling up content.

LOOK AND FEEL

- The game is a newspaper comic page: thick panel borders, gutters, caption boxes.
- While you plan, the scene is drawn in pencil. Pressing ACTION inks it in.
- Darkness is navy halftone dots. Spotlights are warm cones, and anything lit gets its colour back.
- Each thought has an icon, a colour and a word, so it's readable for colour-blind players too.
- Big hand-lettered sound effects, and a DING that goes up in pitch with every link in a chain.
- An editor's red pen corrects each punchline, and your finished strips collect on a Sunday-paper page.

WHAT WE'RE BUILDING IN 100 HOURS

- First, three pages (Nap Time, Midnight Snack, The Boss's Birthday), tested on other people before we build more.
- If those are fun, up to 8 short pages in total, each one teaching a single new idea.
- One shared set of rules for everyone, so a new page is mostly a new layout and some art.
- Very little text. Each page's original strip shows a mechanic before you need it, and you can skip a page after three tries.
- Polish comes before more levels: sound, impact frames, lighting and a quick rewind.
- Not in scope: multiplayer, generated levels, a level editor, physics.

Where we are: the design is finished and the build in Godot is just starting. Everything above is our plan for the jam version; none of it has been built or playtested yet. We'll publish a web build on itch.io.

TEAM

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